

PS: Remember the Address Book

One sure-shot method to speed things up on your PC is to format the hard disk. But this is something you shouldn't do more than once in six months. And if you aren't sure about it, please take help, or better still, leave well enough alone, because if anything goes wrong you will end up losing all data. And that means everything will have to be installed again.

So the best way to proceed is with caution—take a backup of everything. You can do this on a second partition that you won't re-format. A safer bet is to use removable media. Back up important files, folders and other vital data. And don't forget the data in the address book, either Outlook Express or Microsoft Outlook, because it's a tedious job to rewrite all those addresses and e-mail IDs.

To do this in Outlook Express, go to Windows Explorer > Windows > Application Data > Microsoft > Address Book. Copy this Address Book folder completely on your backup media. For Microsoft Outlook, from the main menu open File Import/Export. The wizard will open for importing and exporting files and folders. In this Window, look for the personal folder file (it has a .pst extension) and save it.

Health Tips for your Hard Disk

Do you...

- Empty the Recycle Bin on a regular basis?
- Scan your hard disk after an improper shut-down?
- Always shut down your computer from the Start menu and not by shutting off the power?
- Not open and work with an excessively large number of applications simultaneously?
- Always logically organise your files? If need be, store all your documents on a separate partition so as to facilitate easier backups. Otherwise, at least keep them in a separate directory.
- Avoid storing files and documents in the root directory of your hard disk?
- Preferably, activate the setting 'Do not show hidden/system files' to avoid accidentally erasing crucial files?

file from your system, but just putting it in the Recycle Bin. This gives you a chance to restore a file that has been deleted by mistake. It's important to regularly empty the recycle bin because it eats up disk space.

Help me fight baddies

I am made up of a combination of electro-mechanical components that are precisely fabricated and assembled in one casing. Since so many components are involved, I am prone to physical damage if not handled with care. The most common manifestation of this is a bad sector, which is a sector that gets jarred and damaged.

This can occur due to many reasons, like a scratch on the platters that store information, contamination or demagnetisation.

The remedy for bad sectors is a useful little program called ScanDisk, which scans the disk surface for errors and fixes them. This utility comes with the Windows operating system. You can access it from Accessories > System Tools. The 'Through' test allows ScanDisk to scan the surface of the disk, find and repair errors, and to mark unusable damaged areas.

Once this is done, the area is quarantined so it does not cause a problem in the future. All you need is to be patient and wait till ScanDisk completes the test. Remember to close all programs, especially the screen saver, which interferes with and delays the entire process.

Get a load off me

Besides removing bad sectors, there are other ways you can optimise my performance. One nifty way is to reduce the size of your swap file,

popularly known as virtual memory. In the Windows environment, swapping enables a computer to manipulate programs and data files larger than the main memory. The swap file size could be kept around 300 MB if you are using 64 MB of RAM. This is not a hard and fast rule, though—it finally depends on the type of applications you use.

If the applications are graphics-intensive like PhotoShop or any other 3D-rendering software, where the file size is bigger and the memory subsystem is strained the most, the best way to determine the swap file size is to use the system monitor, which shows the swap usage. To do this, go to Control Panel > Add/Remove program > Windows Setup > System Tools. Click on Details.

This will show you the various system tools. Here, check the box beside System Monitor. Keep the Monitor running while you work at your computer.

At the end of the day, go to the System Monitor and check the 'maximum swap file usage' and decide the swap file size accordingly.

If you're confused about the settings, just choose the 'Let the windows decide my virtual memory' option and Windows will do the needful for you.

A click in time saves nine

One thing I can't understand is why people don't keep their files in a more organised fashion. Most of the time they don't even keep track of where they're saving a document, because they know the four files last opened will be displayed when they next switch on the PC. Do you do this too, and later get into trouble, wasting hours looking for a single misplaced file whose name you've forgotten? Avoid this problem by creating separate folders for different categories and saving all related files accordingly. It only takes a couple of clicks—not like you have to punch holes in reams of paper or arrange stacks of files alphabetically.

Another thing that would go a long way in keeping me fit is switching off the computer the correct way. Improper shutting down or power failure can lead to the FAT table getting damaged, clusters getting lost or orphaned and files getting cross-linked.

Files being used at that time may be lost. On the other hand, shutting your PC from the Start menu allows all the files to close, unwanted files to be deleted, and important files such as system registry files to be copied to the FAT table.

Just see the difference once you've cleaned and optimised me. I'll make the system fly, and applications will open in a flash. So if you don't want to face a hard time when its crunch time, start keeping me in good shape. And that's an order! 